

Robert Falls and the Goodman Theatre

Executive summary

Robert Falls is one of the defining American theatre directors of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries. Born on March 2, 1954, in Springfield, Illinois, and raised in small-town and central Illinois, he built an early identity around reading plays, putting on amateur performances, and then training formally at the University of Illinois, where he earned a BFA in theatre in 1976. Within months of graduating, he had already launched a professional directing career in Chicago, first through a remount of his university production of *Moonchildren* and then through *Of Mice and Men* at Wisdom Bridge Theatre, which led to his appointment as artistic director there in 1977. ¹

His core institutional achievement was Goodman Theatre. Falls became artistic director in 1986, remained in the post through 2022, and programmed the 2022-23 season before fully handing off leadership. Under his stewardship, the Goodman produced more than 150 world premieres, transferred more than two dozen productions to Broadway, and accumulated 22 Tony Awards for those transfers, along with roughly 160 Joseph Jefferson Awards by the theatre's own count. He also helped shape the Goodman's 2000 move into its Loop campus, where the Robert Falls Rehearsal Wing stands as a material mark of his legacy. ²

Artistically, Falls fused large-scale ambition with literary seriousness. He paired new plays with reimagined classics, seeking what he later described as a "dialogue between the classic and the new." His repertory shows a long attraction to epic structures, psychological extremity, and writers who press moral, political, and social contradictions to the surface. That range ran from Brecht, Shakespeare, Chekhov, O'Neill, and Miller to Rebecca Gilman, Steve Tesich, Eric Bogosian, David Henry Hwang, David Cale, and Seth Bockley. His direction was often praised as muscular, bold, and theatrically vivid. Some critics also found it overemphatic or "heavy-handed," especially when he pushed conceptual frameworks hard. ³

The collaborations that most define his public reputation are with actor Brian Dennehy, playwright Rebecca Gilman, producer-administrator Roche Schulfer, and a circle of Goodman artists and designers including Seth Bockley, Ana Kuzmanić, Todd Rosenthal, Walt Spangler, and Henry Godinez. His Dennehy collaborations, especially *Death of a Salesman* and *Long Day's Journey into Night*, cemented his national standing. His Goodman years also made him a leading cultural institution-builder, not only a director of individual productions. He served as board president of Theatre Communications Group, led Northwestern University's graduate directing program for a period, and was elected a Fellow of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences in 2003. ⁴

As of mid-2026, Falls remains active rather than retired. After leaving the Goodman leadership post, he directed *The Cherry Orchard* at the Goodman in 2023, *Steppenwolf's Amadeus* in late 2025, and returned to the Goodman in early 2026 to direct Richard Greenberg's adaptation of *Holiday*. He has described his post-Goodman life as busy freelance work, not retirement. ⁵

Biography and formation

Robert Arthur Falls was born on March 2, 1954, in Springfield, Illinois. Most public biographical accounts agree that he spent formative years in Ashland, Illinois, before later family moves into Champaign-Urbana and then suburban Chicago. His own recollections emphasize isolation, voracious reading, and early self-invention through performance. He told the University of Illinois Alumni Association that at age 11 he read plays “nonstop” in the Ashland library. In Chicago Magazine he described himself as “a major oddity” in small-town Illinois, already putting on plays as a child and memorizing music-theatre recordings by age eight. ⁶

His formal training came at the University of Illinois, where he earned a BFA in theatre in 1976. The Illinois Fine and Applied Arts profile identifies his degree year and credits him with launching his professional directing and producing career almost immediately after graduation. The same institutional account notes that he interrupted an acting pursuit in New York to return to directing, first remounting his university production of Michael Weller’s Moonchildren for Apollo Productions in Chicago. That production won him his first Jeff Award, and his 1977 Wisdom Bridge staging of *Of Mice and Men* earned a second, which in turn led Wisdom Bridge to hire him as artistic director. ⁷

Wisdom Bridge was decisive. Falls later recalled that when he arrived at the old Rogers Park theatre in his early twenties, being “artistic director” often meant cleaning toilets before opening the box office. That anecdote matters because it captures something central to his career. He learned leadership through total institutional labor, not through abstract theory alone. This early phase also taught him how a small ensemble house functions, and it likely shaped the later Goodman model in which artistic identity and institutional structure were tightly linked. ⁸

His family life stayed largely outside his public theatre profile, but several reliable sources confirm that he is married to the novelist Kat Falls and that they have three children. A 2013 Publishers Weekly interview with Kat Falls identified the children by name and ages at the time, and agent and author pages describe the family living in Evanston, Illinois. ⁹

Career arc and institutional leadership

Falls led Wisdom Bridge Theatre from 1977 to 1985. The University of Illinois profile and Britannica both date his artistic directorship there to that span. During those years he established a reputation for bold classical and contemporary work, including *Hamlet*, *Mother Courage and Her Children*, *Tartuffe*, *A Streetcar Named Desire*, *In the Belly of the Beast*, and *Standing on My Knees*, which transferred to Manhattan Theatre Club. His willingness to present artists such as Shozo Sato also broadened the company’s aesthetic range and audience base. ⁷

In 1986, he moved to the Goodman. By his own account, he arrived with larger ambitions than the board initially expected. In a 2023 American Theatre interview, Falls said he wanted “big Brecht productions” and “large Shakespeare” and believed the company needed to regain its energy by going big when others wanted to go small. That same interview shows how self-conscious he was about institutional design. He rejected the lonely, single-director model he had experienced at Wisdom Bridge and instead built the Goodman around associates and the Artistic Collective. ¹⁰

The Goodman of the Falls era was not simply a producing house. It became an artistic home. In a 2006 Goodman-anniversary profile, Falls was described as having directed more than 30 major productions at the theatre by that point and produced or co-produced more than 200 plays and 100 premieres. By the end of his tenure, those totals had grown substantially. WBEZ's 2023 assessment, drawing on the theatre's own records, credited his period of leadership with more than 150 world premieres, more than two dozen Broadway transfers, and 22 Tony Awards for those transfers. ¹¹

His long partnership with Roche Schulfer was crucial. Theatre In Chicago in 2006 described Falls and Schulfer as one of the longest-running artistic/executive leadership pairs in American theatre. Falls himself later said that while he received public credit for the Goodman's artistic achievements, he could not have done the work without Schulfer, especially in relation to the theatre's downtown move. The new building opened in 2000 and became part of the Goodman's transformation from a respected Chicago institution into a nationally central regional theatre. ¹¹

He announced in September 2021 that he would step down as artistic director at the close of the 2021-22 season, though he would still program the following season. WBEZ later clarified the arrangement: Falls left the artistic director post at the close of 2021-22, and 2022-23 was the last season he programmed. Susan V. Booth succeeded him, assuming Goodman leadership in October 2022. ¹²

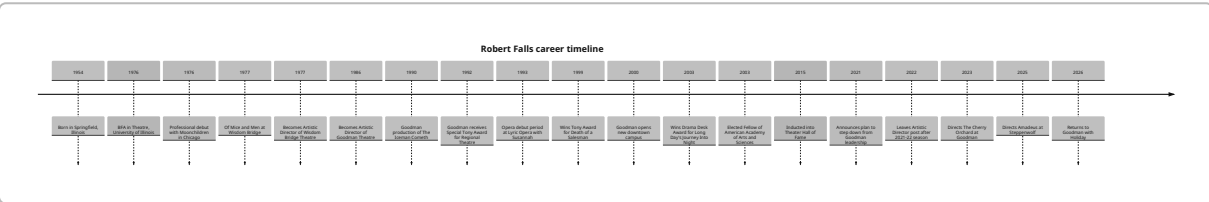
Positions and affiliations table

Role or affiliation	Institution	Years	Notes
BFA student in theatre	University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	through 1976	Graduated with BFA in 1976. ¹³
Artistic Director	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	1977-1985	Appointed after Of Mice and Men. Built Chicago reputation in classics, premieres, and experimental work. ⁷
Artistic Director	Goodman Theatre	1986-2022	Led theatre for 35 to 36 years depending on whether one counts the final programmed season after formal leadership transition. ¹⁴
Final season programmer after leadership transition	Goodman Theatre	2022-2023	Programmed 2022-23 after stepping down from the post. ¹⁵
Past Board President	Theatre Communications Group	date not readily surfaced in consulted open sources	Confirmed in Goodman anniversary profile. ¹⁶

Role or affiliation	Institution	Years	Notes
Past Artistic Director of graduate directing program	Northwestern University	date not readily surfaced in consulted open sources	Confirmed in Goodman anniversary profile. ¹⁶
Fellow	American Academy of Arts and Sciences	elected 2003	Entry lists his affiliation at election as Goodman Theatre and Northwestern University. ¹⁷
Guest director after Goodman tenure	Goodman Theatre	2023, 2026	Directed The Cherry Orchard and Holiday after stepping down. ¹⁸
Guest director	Steppenwolf Theatre Company	2025–2026 season	Directed Amadeus. ¹⁹
Opera director	Lyric Opera of Chicago and other opera companies	1993 onward	Credits include Susannah, The Consul, and Don Giovanni. ²⁰

Career timeline

The timeline below synthesizes the best-documented milestones from official and institutional sources. ²¹



Directing record

The table below is designed as the most complete open-source chronology recoverable from the consulted record. For 1976 through 2006, the base chronology comes from Goodman's 2006 anniversary production history published by Theatre In Chicago. Later entries are cross-checked against Goodman pages, IBDB, Lyric Opera of Chicago, Steppenwolf, and contemporary coverage. Cast highlights appear where they were readily verifiable from official or major-source materials. Some early casts, some workshop or developmental projects, and a few exact season-opening dates are not fully documented in open public sources consulted for this report. ²²

Chronological productions table

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
1976	Moonchildren	Michael Weller	Apollo Productions, St. Nicholas Theatre, Chicago	Remount of Falls's university production. Early professional breakthrough. ²³
1976	The Wax Museum	John Hawkes	Direct Theatre, New York	Early New York professional credit. ¹⁶
1977	Of Mice and Men	John Steinbeck	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Earned Falls a Jeff and led to his Wisdom Bridge appointment. ²³
1977	The Tempest	William Shakespeare	Court Theatre, University of Chicago	Early Shakespeare credit; also awarded by Jeff Awards archives. ²⁴
1977	Ladyhouse Blues	Kevin O'Morrison	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Wisdom Bridge period. ¹⁶
1978	The Runner Stumbles	Milan Stitt	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Midwest premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1978	Happy End	Bertolt Brecht and Kurt Weill	SCT Productions, Athenaeum Theatre, Chicago	Early Brecht/Weill credit. ¹⁶
1978	Othello	William Shakespeare	Oak Park Shakespeare Festival	Outdoor Shakespeare credit. ¹⁶
1978	Fits and Starts	Grace McKeaney	Northlight Theatre, Evanston	World-premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1978	The Idiots Karamazov	Albert Innaurato and Christopher Durang	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Comic contemporary adaptation. ¹⁶
1979	Wings	Arthur Kopit	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Midwest premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1979	Bagtime	Alan Rosen, Louis Rosen, Thom Bishop	Wisdom Bridge and Drury Lane Water Tower co-production	World premiere. ¹⁶

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
1979	Curse of the Starving Class	Sam Shepard	Goodman Theatre Stage 2	Goodman credit before his later artistic directorship. ¹⁶
1979	Tartuffe	Molière	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Co-directed with Michael Maggio. ¹⁶
1980	Yentl	Isaac Bashevis Singer and Leah Napolin	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Midwest premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1980	Getting Out	Marsha Norman	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Midwest premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1980	The Importance of Being Earnest and Travesties	Oscar Wilde and Tom Stoppard	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Rotating repertory presentation. ¹⁶
1981	Standing on My Knees	John Olive	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	World premiere, later transferred to Manhattan Theatre Club. ²³
1981	Mother Courage and Her Children	Bertolt Brecht	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Prefigures Falls's later large-scale Brecht ambitions. ²⁵
1981	A Sorrow Beyond Dreams	Peter Handke	St. Nicholas Theatre, Chicago	Experimental literary adaptation. ¹⁶
1981	Bent	Martin Sherman	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Midwest premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1982	We Won't Pay, We Won't Pay	Dario Fo	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Midwest premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1982	Sister Mary Ignatius Explains It All for You / The Actor's Nightmare	Christopher Durang	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Double bill, Midwest premiere note. ¹⁶
1982	A Streetcar Named Desire	Tennessee Williams	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Later recalled by Falls in Chicago Magazine. ²⁶

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
1983	In the Belly of the Beast	Jack Abbott	Wisdom Bridge at Goodman Studio Theatre	World-premiere adaptation. Often cited among his most unforgettable early works. William L. Petersen is associated with the production in later remembrance. ²⁷
1983	Losing It	Jon Klein	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Contemporary drama. ¹⁶
1984	Terra Nova	Ted Tally	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Major literary-historical drama. ¹⁶
1984	Careless Love	John Olive	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Continued Olive collaboration. ¹⁶
1984	Life and Limb	Keith Reddin	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	World premiere note. ¹⁶
1985	In the Belly of the Beast	Jack Abbott	Mayfest Glasgow, Lyric Hammersmith Studio London, Ivanhoe Theatre Chicago	International transfer of the adaptation. ¹⁶
1985	Hamlet	William Shakespeare	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Starred Aidan Quinn according to later profile. Last major Wisdom Bridge landmark before Goodman transition. ²⁸
1986	Orchards	Adaptations by Fornés, Gray, Guare, Mamet, Wasserstein, Weller, Samm-Art Williams	The Acting Company, New York and tour	Chekhov adaptation cycle. ¹⁶
1987	Galileo	Bertolt Brecht	Goodman Theatre	Falls's Goodman directorial debut. Began the long Brian Dennehy partnership and signaled a "muscular" new Goodman direction. ²⁹
1987	The Tempest	William Shakespeare	Goodman Theatre	Major early Goodman Shakespeare. ¹⁶

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
1987	Road	Jim Cartwright	Remains Theatre, Chicago	American-premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1988	Pal Joey	Rodgers, Hart, and John O'Hara	Goodman Theatre	Falls later wrote a new book for the musical, an important marker of his music-theatre practice. ³⁰
1988	Landscape of the Body	John Guare	Goodman Theatre	Modern classic at Goodman. ³⁰
1989	The Misanthrope	Molière, adapted by Neil Bartlett	Goodman and La Jolla Playhouse co-production	Falls later counted it among the notable Goodman credits of his career. ³¹
1989	The Speed of Darkness	Steve Tesich	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. Later transferred to Broadway. ³²
1989	Pravda	Howard Brenton and David Hare	Guthrie Theatre	American-premiere note in anniversary list. ¹⁶
1990	The Iceman Cometh	Eugene O'Neill	Goodman Theatre	Brian Dennehy starred in the Goodman staging, later remounted in Dublin and revisited by Falls in 2012-15. ³³
1991	Book of the Night	Louis Rosen and Thom Bishop	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. ¹⁶
1991	The Speed of Darkness	Steve Tesich	Belasco Theatre, Broadway	Broadway transfer of Goodman world premiere. ³²
1992	The Iceman Cometh	Eugene O'Neill	Abbey Theatre, Dublin	Anniversary profile calls it a high point of the Dublin Theatre Festival. ¹⁶
1992	Riverview	John Logan	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. Falls later cited John Logan as a major collaborator. ³⁴
1992	On the Open Road	Steve Tesich	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. Later staged at New York Shakespeare Festival. ¹⁶

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
1993	Susannah	Carlisle Floyd	Lyric Opera of Chicago	Early opera milestone. Later revived at the Met and elsewhere. ³⁵
1993	On the Open Road	Steve Tesich	New York Shakespeare Festival	New York staging of Goodman original. ¹⁶
1994	subUrbia	Eric Bogosian	Lincoln Center Theater, New York	Won Falls the Obie Award for direction. ³⁶
1994	The Night of the Iguana	Tennessee Williams	Goodman Theatre	Preceded Broadway transfer. ³²
1995	The Food Chain	Nicky Silver	Westside Theatre, New York	Off-Broadway credit later listed by Steppenwolf. ³⁰
1995	The Rose Tattoo	Tennessee Williams	Circle in the Square, Broadway	Starred Anthony LaPaglia and Mercedes Ruehl. Tony-nominated revival. ³²
1995	Three Sisters	Anton Chekhov	Goodman Theatre	Later cited by Falls as part of his classic/new dialogue strategy. ²⁵
1996	A Touch of the Poet	Eugene O'Neill	Goodman Theatre	Brian Dennehy collaboration within Falls's O'Neill cycle. ³⁷
1996	The Consul	Gian Carlo Menotti	Lyric Opera of Chicago	Significant opera credit. ³⁵
1996	The Night of the Iguana	Tennessee Williams	Broadway	Broadway staging confirmed by IBDB. ³²
1997	Griller	Eric Bogosian	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. Falls later named it among his signature premieres. ³⁴
1997	The Young Man from Atlanta	Horton Foote	Goodman Theatre and Broadway	Goodman production starred Rip Torn and Shirley Knight. Broadway nomination for Best Play. ³²
1998	Death of a Salesman	Arthur Miller	Goodman Theatre	Brian Dennehy as Willy Loman. Became the basis for the Tony-winning Broadway revival. ³⁸

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
1999	Death of a Salesman	Arthur Miller	Eugene O'Neill Theatre, Broadway	Dennehy starred. Falls won the Tony for Best Direction. ³⁹
1999	Aida	Elton John and Tim Rice	Chicago pre-Broadway run	Falls directed and wrote the book for the Broadway production path. ³²
1999	Susannah	Carlisle Floyd	Metropolitan Opera, New York	Follow-on major opera credit. ³⁵
2000	Aida	Elton John and Tim Rice	Broadway	Directed by Falls and credited with the book. ⁴⁰
2001	Blue Surge	Rebecca Gilman	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. Start of an important public Gilman-Falls run at the Goodman. ⁴¹
2001	House and Garden	Alan Ayckbourn	Goodman Theatre	American premiere. Dual-play event noted in Goodman bios. ³⁴
2001	Aida	Elton John and Tim Rice	National tour	Continuing afterlife of the musical. ³²
2002	Long Day's Journey into Night	Eugene O'Neill	Goodman Theatre	Chicago staging preceded the 2003 Broadway transfer and Drama Desk win. Exact Chicago opening year follows IBDB transfer note. ⁴⁰
2003	Long Day's Journey into Night	Eugene O'Neill	Broadway	Brian Dennehy, Vanessa Redgrave, Philip Seymour Hoffman, Robert Sean Leonard. Falls won Drama Desk; Tony-nominated. ⁴²
2003	The Goat, or Who Is Sylvia?	Edward Albee	Goodman Theatre	Midwest premiere per anniversary list. ⁴³
2003	The Guys	Anne Nelson	Goodman and Northlight co-production	Co-production noted in anniversary list. ¹⁶
2003	Blue Surge	Rebecca Gilman	Joseph Papp Public Theater, New York	Off-Broadway continuation of Gilman collaboration. ³⁰

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
2003	Aida	Elton John and Tim Rice	Netherlands	International mounting. ¹⁶
2004	Hughie	Eugene O'Neill	Goodman Theatre	Another Dennehy/O'Neill chapter. ³⁷
2004	Finishing the Picture	Arthur Miller	Goodman Theatre	World premiere of Miller's final play. ³⁴
2005	Dollhouse	Rebecca Gilman	Goodman Theatre	World premiere adaptation of Ibsen. Widely discussed as a bold update. ⁴⁴
2005	Death of a Salesman	Arthur Miller	Lyric Theatre, London	London remount of the Dennehy-centered staging. ¹⁶
2005	Aida	Elton John and Tim Rice	Germany, Japan, South Korea	International productions. ¹⁶
2006	King Lear	William Shakespeare	Goodman Theatre	Stacy Keach starred. The production later remounted in Washington. ⁴⁵
2006	Frank's Home	Richard Nelson	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. ¹⁶
2006	Shining City	Conor McPherson	Manhattan Theatre Club, Broadway	Tony-nominated Broadway staging. ³²
2006	A Life in the Theatre	David Mamet	Goodman Theatre	Goodman staging during Falls's twentieth-anniversary season. ¹⁶
2008	American Buffalo	David Mamet	Broadway	IBDB credit. ⁴⁰
2009	Desire Under the Elms	Eugene O'Neill	Goodman Theatre and Broadway	Major late Dennehy/O'Neill collaboration; Broadway transfer confirmed by IBDB and Steppenwolf bio. ⁴⁶
2009	King Lear	William Shakespeare	Shakespeare Theatre Company, Washington	Remount of the 2006 Goodman production. Helen Hayes award is associated with this production. ⁴⁷
2010	The Seagull	Anton Chekhov, adapted by Falls	Goodman Theatre	Falls later called the rehearsal process "life-changing." ⁴⁸

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
2011	Chinglish	David Henry Hwang	Goodman Theatre and Broadway	Goodman world premiere in June 2011, Broadway opening October 2011. ⁴⁹
2012	The Iceman Cometh	Eugene O'Neill	Goodman Theatre	2012 revival later moved to BAM. Brian Dennehy played Larry Slade, Nathan Lane Hickey, with John Douglas Thompson in the cast. ⁵⁰
2013	Luna Gale	Rebecca Gilman	Goodman Theatre	World premiere. Later directed by Falls at the Kirk Douglas Theatre in Los Angeles. ⁵¹
2013	The Jacksonian	Beth Henley	Goodman Theatre	World premiere; later played Off-Broadway and in Los Angeles. ⁵²
2014	The Jacksonian	Beth Henley	Off-Broadway	Off-Broadway continuation of Goodman premiere. ⁵³
2014	Luna Gale	Rebecca Gilman	Kirk Douglas Theatre, Los Angeles	Los Angeles transfer/remount. ⁵⁴
2014–15	Don Giovanni	Mozart	Lyric Opera of Chicago	Opera production later remounted in Dallas. ⁵⁵
2015	The Iceman Cometh	Eugene O'Neill	Brooklyn Academy of Music	Featured Dennehy, Nathan Lane, John Douglas Thompson and others. ⁵⁶
2016	Soups, Stews, and Casseroles: 1976	Rebecca Gilman	Goodman Theatre	Chicago premiere. Cast included Cliff Chamberlain, Cora Vander Broek, Lindsay Stock, Angela Reed, and Ty Olwin. ⁵⁷
2016	2666	Roberto Bolaño, adapted by Falls and Seth Bockley	Goodman Theatre	Five-and-a-half-hour world-premiere adaptation. Ensemble included Charín Alvarez, Janet Ulrich Brooks, Yadira Correa, Henry Godinez, Larry Grimm, Eric Lynch, Sean Fortunato, Juan Francisco Villa and others. ⁵⁸

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
2017	Uncle Vanya	Anton Chekhov, adapted by Annie Baker	Goodman Theatre	Cast highlights include Tim Hopper, Marton Csokas, and Kristen Bush. ⁵⁷
2017	Pamplona	Jim McGrath	Goodman Theatre	World premiere starring Stacy Keach as Hemingway. A 2018 remount followed his health crisis during the initial run. ⁵⁹
2018	Blind Date	Rogelio Martinez	Goodman Theatre	Falls-directed world premiere inferred from Goodman's Enemy press language describing Enemy as following "his world premiere production of Blind Date." ⁶⁰
2018	An Enemy of the People	Henrik Ibsen, adapted by Falls	Goodman Theatre	Falls's own adaptation. Critics split between praise for its urgency and criticism of its looseness from Ibsen. ⁶¹
2018	We're Only Alive for a Short Amount of Time	David Cale	Goodman Theatre	Musical memoir directed by Falls. Audience and review response was strongly positive, though some critics thought the Albert stage too large for its intimacy. ⁶²
2019	We're Only Alive for a Short Amount of Time	David Cale	Public Theater, New York	Transfer of Goodman production. ⁶³
2019	The Winter's Tale	William Shakespeare	Goodman Theatre	Review response ranged from praise for inventiveness to concerns about imbalance and excess. ⁶⁴
2019–20	Molly Sweeney	Brian Friel	Goodman Theatre	Confirmed by Lyric bio as Falls's Goodman production in the year before the 2019 Don Giovanni biography update. ⁵⁵

Year	Production	Playwright or composer	Venue	Cast highlights and production notes
2019–20	Don Giovanni	Mozart	Lyric Opera of Chicago	Later remounted in Dallas in 2020. ⁵⁵
2020	Don Giovanni	Mozart	Dallas Opera	Dallas remount of Falls's production. ⁶⁵
2021	The Sound Inside	Adam Rapp	Goodman Theatre Live series	Starring Mary Beth Fisher and John Drea. Live-streamed from the Owen Theatre. ⁶⁶
2022	Swing State	Rebecca Gilman	Goodman Theatre	Falls and Gilman's sixth Goodman collaboration by the theatre's count. ⁶⁷
2023	The Cherry Orchard	Anton Chekhov, adapted by Falls	Goodman Theatre	The last season he programmed and his valedictory Goodman production after leaving the post. ⁶⁸
2025	Amadeus	Peter Shaffer	Steppenwolf Theatre Company	Steppenwolf directorial debut. Featured Ian Barford, Robert Breuler, Ora Jones, and Yasen Peyankov. ¹⁹
2026	Holiday	Philip Barry, adapted by Richard Greenberg	Goodman Theatre	Contemporary revival directed by Falls. Cast includes Jessie Fisher, Erik Hellman, Molly Griggs, Bryce Gangel and others. ⁶⁹

Collaborations, style, and critical reception

Falls's work is best understood through his collaborations. The single most important artistic partnership was with Brian Dennehy. Their Goodman and Broadway work together included *Galileo*, *The Iceman Cometh*, *A Touch of the Poet*, *Death of a Salesman*, *Long Day's Journey into Night*, *Hughie*, and *Desire Under the Elms*. Dennehy became the central actor through whom Falls tested his approach to O'Neill, Miller, and the Shakespearean or Brechtian large form. WBEZ described Dennehy as a Goodman artistic associate for decades whose relationship with Falls went back to Wisdom Bridge in the late 1970s. ⁷⁰

His most enduring playwright collaboration was with Rebecca Gilman. Goodman and American Theatre sources identify at least six Goodman productions shared by Gilman and Falls, including *Blue Surge*, *Dollhouse*, *Luna Gale*, *Soups, Stews, and Casseroles*: 1976, and *Swing State*. Falls said in 2023 that when he first saw one of Gilman's early plays in a suburban black box, he immediately knew she was a writer he

wanted to build an artistic home around. That statement fits the institutional pattern of his Goodman years. He did not merely “present” playwrights. He built repeated production pathways around them. ⁷¹

Other major collaborators include Seth Bockley on 2666, Roche Schulfer on institutional leadership, Henry Godinez and other Goodman Artistic Collective members on season-shaping, and designers such as Ana Kuzmanić and Walt Spangler. Falls repeatedly emphasized the work of collectives and associates. In American Theatre he explicitly linked the Goodman structure to Citizens Theatre in Glasgow and the Royal Shakespeare Company. He said he wanted colleagues around him so he could avoid the loneliness of a single-director system and benefit from others’ ideas. ⁷²

The clearest concise statement of his directing style came from Falls himself in 2010. “Every show has its own explosions,” he said. He “underlines” them, while acknowledging that some people accuse him of doing so “with a heavy hand.” That line is unusually revealing. It explains both the admiration and the resistance he generated. His stagings were rarely shy. They sought clarity through force, structure through emphasis, and emotional propulsion through theatrical pressure. ⁷³

His own later self-description complicates the “heavy hand” image. In the 2023 American Theatre interview, he framed his Goodman career as a continuous alternation between premieres and classics, with an often unconscious but deep personal connection to both. He also described certain productions, especially *The Seagull*, as requiring unusually long rehearsal periods in pursuit of a more spontaneous, actor-immersed form. Newcity’s 2023 Cherry Orchard interview records Falls speaking about Michael Alfreds’s idea that a play becomes “different every night” when actors are intensely trained and immersed rather than over-directed. ⁷⁴

Critical response followed a stable pattern across decades. Major high points were emphatic. Variety found *Death of a Salesman* “solid and respectable” and emotionally powerful in stretches, while the New York Times, as quoted by Goodman and Theatre Communications Group materials, praised Dennehy’s transparency and Falls’s “powerhouse staging.” Variety called *Long Day’s Journey into Night* “superlative,” praising how Falls’s cast found new emotional depth in a canonical play. For *King Lear* in 2006, Variety called his production “bold and brash,” while some Chicago critics admired its muscularity and political immediacy. ⁷⁵

At the same time, resistance often focused on scale, imbalance, or conceptual overstatement. One Chicago review of *The Seagull* argued that Falls’s exploratory approach produced stunning moments but needed tighter control. Reviews of *The Winter’s Tale* divided similarly, with some critics praising its inventiveness and others calling it unwieldy or imbalanced. His 2018 adaptation of *An Enemy of the People* drew especially split reactions. Newcity criticized the production’s spectacle-heavy visual frame and its loose modernization of Ibsen, while WTTW praised its “rip-roaring” relevance to the political present. ⁷⁶

Taken together, the reviews show a director whose failures and successes came from the same source. Falls favored ambitious, pressure-filled, often high-concept theatre. When the concept locked into the material, the result was landmark work. When it overran the text, critics noticed. That consistency is one reason his body of work remains analytically interesting. ⁷⁷

Awards, honors, mentorship, archives, and current status

Falls's confirmed major awards are substantial and span local, national, and institutional recognition. IBDB confirms the 1999 Tony Award for Best Direction of a Play for *Death of a Salesman*, the 2003 Drama Desk Award for Outstanding Director of a Play for *Long Day's Journey into Night*, and his 2015 induction into the Theater Hall of Fame. The Obie Awards site confirms his 1995 Obie for directing *subUrbia*. Goodman and other bios consistently add a Helen Hayes Award for *King Lear*, multiple Jeff Awards, the O'Neill Medallion, the Savva Morozov Diamond Award, and the Illinois Arts Council Governor's Award. The American Academy of Arts and Sciences elected him a Fellow in 2003, and Lake Forest College awarded him an honorary Doctor of Fine Arts in 2006. In 2023 the Jeff Awards gave him a special award for lifelong commitment to Chicago theatre. ⁷⁸

Awards and honors table

Year	Award or honor	Work or basis	Source
1992	Special Tony Award for Outstanding Regional Theatre	Goodman Theatre under Falls and Roche Schulfer	⁴⁰
1995	Obie Award for Direction	<i>subUrbia</i>	⁷⁹
1999	Tony Award for Best Direction of a Play	<i>Death of a Salesman</i>	³⁹
1999	Illinois Arts Council Governor's Award	Individual artistic achievement	¹⁶
2000	Chicagoan of the Year	Chicago Magazine recognition	¹⁶
2003	Drama Desk Award for Outstanding Director of a Play	<i>Long Day's Journey into Night</i>	⁴⁰
2003	Fellow, American Academy of Arts and Sciences	Election as Fellow	¹⁷
2006	Honorary Doctor of Fine Arts	Lake Forest College	⁸⁰
year not readily surfaced	Helen Hayes Award	<i>King Lear</i>	⁸¹
year not readily surfaced	O'Neill Medallion	Career contribution to O'Neill studies and production	⁸²
year not readily surfaced	Savva Morozov Diamond Award	Moscow Art Theatre honor	⁸²
year not readily surfaced	Distinguished Service to the Arts Award	<i>Lawyers for the Creative Arts</i>	⁸³
2015	Theater Hall of Fame induction	Career achievement	⁸⁴

Year	Award or honor	Work or basis	Source
2023	Jeff Awards Special Award	Lifelong commitment to Chicago theatre	85

Mentorship is one of the less glamorous but more consequential parts of Falls's record. He repeatedly described the Goodman's mission as creating an "artistic home" for artists to do their best work. WBEZ highlighted this as his own preferred account of success. Rather than naming a single production as his greatest achievement, Falls pointed to the Artistic Collective and the structure of support he created for other artists. The Goodman's enduring fellowship architecture, including the Michael Maggio Directing Fellowship and the Northwestern Directing Fellowship, grew within the institutional culture he helped shape, although those programs belong to the theatre rather than to him personally. 86

The same pattern appears in his educational and field roles. Theatre In Chicago identifies him as a past board president of Theatre Communications Group and a past artistic director of Northwestern University's graduate directing program. The American Academy record lists Northwestern University among his affiliations at election in 2003. Public open-source evidence for a detailed Northwestern teaching chronology is thin, so the exact dates and scope of that pedagogical role remain a gap in the available record. 87

Archival and interview materials are unusually rich. They include Goodman press-room photographs and production files, the 1999 American Theatre Wing "Working in the Theatre" clip, PBS NewsHour's 2009 conversation with Falls and Dennehy about O'Neill, multiple American Theatre interviews, WBEZ feature interviews, the Reduced Shakespeare Company podcast interview from 2019, and the 2026 Eugene O'Neill Review interview "An Interview with the Abnormally Normal Robert Falls." These materials make Falls especially well documented as both practitioner and institution-builder. 88

As of June 2026, Falls is professionally active. Goodman materials describe Holiday as his newest Goodman production in the theatre's 2025-26 centennial season. Steppenwolf's 2025-26 season materials identify him as director of Amadeus. A January 2026 Newcity interview quotes Falls saying flatly, "It's certainly not a retirement." 89

Representative images and captions

The four images displayed at the top of this report are representative rather than exhaustive. They illustrate Falls in rehearsal, the collaborative machinery around 2666, his recent post-Goodman freelance phase, and his 2026 Goodman return with Holiday. The image sources are: the Daily Herald rehearsal feature on Falls's Goodman tenure, the Goodman press-room photo for 2666, WBEZ's 2025 portrait feature tied to Amadeus, and the Daily Herald's 2026 Holiday rehearsal coverage. 90

Influence, legacy, source notes, and annotated bibliography

Falls's influence on American theatre sits at the intersection of artistry and infrastructure. As a director, he belongs to the generation that proved a regional-theatre production could begin in Chicago and end as a Broadway event without losing artistic seriousness. As a leader, he helped consolidate the model of the major resident theatre as a local civic institution with national reach. The Goodman under Falls became

both a new-play incubator and a classics powerhouse. That mix remains one of his most durable contributions. ⁹¹

He also matters because he resisted narrow specialization. He moved between small-scale contemporary writing, giant literary adaptations, Shakespeare, O'Neill, Brecht, music theatre, and opera. That breadth gave his career unusual internal tension. He was never only a "literary" director or only a "producer-director" or only a "conceptual" director. His work kept testing whether a big public theatre could hold all those modes at once. In American terms, that is close to a definition of artistic directorship itself. ⁹²

There are, however, real evidentiary gaps. No single open public database lists every Falls-directed production with complete cast and production staff. Goodman's present website highlights recent and selected earlier work but does not expose a full machine-readable credit list. The 2006 anniversary chronology is the best open source for the early and middle career, but it naturally stops there. Some later productions are documented only through bios, season pages, press materials, or transfer records. The table above should therefore be read as the most rigorous open-source reconstruction available from the consulted materials, not as a substitute for a full archival catalogue raisonné. ⁹³

Annotated bibliography

Goodman Theatre artist bio and press-room pages are the most important primary institutional sources for Falls's late-career credits, honors, and photo documentation. They are especially useful for verifying how the theatre itself narrates his career and which productions it emphasizes. ⁹⁴

The University of Illinois Fine and Applied Arts profile and the University of Illinois Alumni Association feature are the clearest open sources for Falls's early life, education, and launch into professional directing. They also connect his Illinois upbringing to his later Chicago career in a detailed way. ¹³

The 2006 Theatre In Chicago anniversary feature is indispensable because it reproduces a 30-year production list, including many Wisdom Bridge, early Goodman, Broadway, and opera credits that are otherwise scattered across different databases. It is the backbone of any open-source chronology through 2006. ¹⁶

IBDB provides the most authoritative open record of Falls's Broadway credits and award results, especially for Tony and Drama Desk data. It is the cleanest source for Broadway transfer validation. ⁴⁰

American Theatre's 2023 interview "Robert Falls: Letting Go of the Goodman" is the best single source for his mature artistic self-understanding. It explains his philosophy of alternating classics and new work, his collective model, and his sense of the Goodman's institutional mission. ¹⁰

WBEZ's 2023 feature on Falls's legacy is the strongest post-tenure synthesis. It combines institutional outcomes, personal reflection, and context about the Goodman's building, collective, and transfer history. ¹⁵

Lyric Opera of Chicago and Steppenwolf artist pages are essential for filling out Falls's opera and post-Goodman freelance phases, especially Don Giovanni and Amadeus. ⁹⁵

The American Academy of Arts and Sciences member record adds an important non-theatre institutional marker. It confirms his 2003 election and his affiliation at that moment with both Goodman Theatre and Northwestern University. ¹⁷

¹ ⁶ <https://www.britannica.com/biography/Robert-Falls>

<https://www.britannica.com/biography/Robert-Falls>

² ¹² ¹⁴ <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/robert-falls-announcement/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/robert-falls-announcement/>

³ ⁵ ¹⁰ ¹⁸ ⁶⁸ ⁷² ⁷⁴ <https://www.americantheatre.org/2023/03/29/robert-falls-letting-go-of-the-goodman/>

<https://www.americantheatre.org/2023/03/29/robert-falls-letting-go-of-the-goodman/>

⁴ ¹¹ ¹⁶ ²² ²⁴ ²⁵ ²⁶ ²⁷ ²⁸ ²⁹ ³⁰ ³¹ ³² ³³ ³⁴ ³⁵ ³⁶ ³⁷ ³⁸ ⁴¹ ⁴³ ⁴⁴ ⁴⁵ ⁸⁷ ⁹¹ ⁹³ <https://www.theatreinchicago.com/articles/artistic-director-robert-falls-celebrates-20-years-at-the-goodman/137/>

<https://www.theatreinchicago.com/articles/artistic-director-robert-falls-celebrates-20-years-at-the-goodman/137/>

⁷ ¹³ ²¹ ²³ <https://faa.illinois.edu/alumni-friends/faa-legacy-awards/previous-legacy-award-recipients/robert-falls/>

<https://faa.illinois.edu/alumni-friends/faa-legacy-awards/previous-legacy-award-recipients/robert-falls/>

⁸ <https://www.chicagomag.com/chicago-magazine/march-2017/robert-falls/>

<https://www.chicagomag.com/chicago-magazine/march-2017/robert-falls/>

⁹ <https://www.adamsliterary.com/kat-falls>

<https://www.adamsliterary.com/kat-falls>

¹⁵ ⁷⁰ ⁷¹ ⁸⁶ <https://www.wbez.org/culture-the-arts/2023/06/08/robert-falls-leaves-legacy-at-goodman-theatre>

<https://www.wbez.org/culture-the-arts/2023/06/08/robert-falls-leaves-legacy-at-goodman-theatre>

¹⁷ <https://www.amacad.org/sites/default/files/academy/multimedia/pdfs/publications/bookofmembers/ChapterF.pdf>

<https://www.amacad.org/sites/default/files/academy/multimedia/pdfs/publications/bookofmembers/ChapterF.pdf>

¹⁹ <https://www.steppenwolf.org/amadeus>

<https://www.steppenwolf.org/amadeus>

²⁰ ⁵⁵ ⁹⁵ <https://www.lyricopera.org/about/company/artists-musicians/robert-falls/>

<https://www.lyricopera.org/about/company/artists-musicians/robert-falls/>

³⁹ ⁴⁰ ⁴² ⁴⁶ ⁴⁹ ⁷⁸ ⁸⁴ <https://www.ibdb.com/broadway-cast-staff/robert-falls-14741>

<https://www.ibdb.com/broadway-cast-staff/robert-falls-14741>

⁴⁷ <https://www.shakespearetheatre.org/events/king-lear-08-09>

<https://www.shakespearetheatre.org/events/king-lear-08-09>

⁴⁸ <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/the-seagull-11/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/the-seagull-11/>

⁵⁰ ⁵² ⁵³ ⁵⁴ ⁵⁶ ⁵⁷ ⁵⁸ ⁵⁹ ⁸⁸ <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/robert-falls/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/robert-falls/>

51 92 <https://www.steppenwolf.org/artists/robert-falls/>

<https://www.steppenwolf.org/artists/robert-falls/>

60 61 <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/an-enemy-of-the-people/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/an-enemy-of-the-people/>

62 <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/were-only-alive-for-a-short-amount-of-time/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/were-only-alive-for-a-short-amount-of-time/>

63 <https://playbill.com/article/what-did-critics-think-of-were-only-alive-for-a-short-amount-of-time-at-the-public-theater>

<https://playbill.com/article/what-did-critics-think-of-were-only-alive-for-a-short-amount-of-time-at-the-public-theater>

64 81 82 94 <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/artists/robert-falls-2/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/artists/robert-falls-2/>

65 <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/03/2025-2026-Centennial-Season-Announcement-FINAL.docx>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/03/2025-2026-Centennial-Season-Announcement-FINAL.docx>

66 <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/the-sound-inside/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/the-sound-inside/>

67 <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/swing-state/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/press-rooms/swing-state/>

69 89 <https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/holiday/>

<https://www.goodmantheatre.org/show/holiday/>

73 77 <https://www.chicagomag.com/chicago-magazine/october-2010/inside-the-mind-of-goodman-theatre-artistic-director-robert-falls/>

<https://www.chicagomag.com/chicago-magazine/october-2010/inside-the-mind-of-goodman-theatre-artistic-director-robert-falls/>

75 <https://variety.com/1999/legit/reviews/death-of-a-salesman-11-1200456637/>

<https://variety.com/1999/legit/reviews/death-of-a-salesman-11-1200456637/>

76 <https://www.theatreinchicago.com/the-seagull/4166/>

<https://www.theatreinchicago.com/the-seagull/4166/>

79 <https://www.obieawards.com/events/1990s/year-95/>

<https://www.obieawards.com/events/1990s/year-95/>

80 <https://www.lakeforest.edu/about-us/commencement/honorary-degree-recipients>

<https://www.lakeforest.edu/about-us/commencement/honorary-degree-recipients>

83 https://dallasopera.org/crew_member/robert-falls/

https://dallasopera.org/crew_member/robert-falls/

85 <https://www.americantheatre.org/2023/10/04/goodman-teatro-vista-take-centerstage-at-equity-jeff-awards/>

<https://www.americantheatre.org/2023/10/04/goodman-teatro-vista-take-centerstage-at-equity-jeff-awards/>

90 <https://www.dailyherald.com/20170303/entertainment/robert-falls-celebrates-30-years-as-goodmans-driving-artistic-force/>

<https://www.dailyherald.com/20170303/entertainment/robert-falls-celebrates-30-years-as-goodmans-driving-artistic-force/>